I'm Not Your Son, I am No One You Know

By Joyce Carol Oates

DON'T MAKE EYE contact my brother warned. They'll be waiting just inside. Deftly my brother punched in the code he knew by heart. I had to be impressed, this was my younger brother and he seemed possessed of a grim knowledge of which I was ignorant.

A hefty double door with inset wire-lattice windows. Overhead, a video monitor. As soon as my brother punched in the code, the doors slid open and we stepped inside. Already the figures waiting just inside pressed forward. There were three of them. Dad won't be among them, my brother had promised. Yet my heart began to clamor, I felt sweat breaking out in all the pores of my clumsy body.

Hel-lo? *Hel-lo?* Son? Son? Son? *Son?*

The voices were calling to us, pleading. My instinct was to stop, to stare. An elderly woman with

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white hair lifting from her skull like electrified wire filings, a sunken-chested elderly man with a singed-looking face, a gnome-sized individual of no evident sex leaning on a walker and piping like an eager parrot, "Take me? Take me? Boys? Sons? I'm ready now. My things are ready. Take me with you? " On his bony skull thick-lensed glasses were secured by an elastic band. The smell of them was acrid as the befouled wettish-rotting , straw in which goats dwell.

INTRODUCTION

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My brother yanked at me. Jesus! I told you come *on.*

Yet somehow in that instant I stood stone-still, unmoving. For these elderly strangers seemed to know me-how? They were pleading, scolding, bleating. Their faces were familiar to me in some way I could not comprehend. The white-haired woman had a fattish fallen body soft as a pudding but her eyes were vigilant,

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alert to insult. Here was a mother's voice-Dear? Dear? Come back here! Don't you walk away while I'm talking to you! Don't you walk away while I'm talking to you!-you could not ignore. And the others were crying to me, calling me Son. *Son!*

My brother pulled me away. Blindly we walked along the corridor.

Even now I wanted badly to look back. I wanted to explain, apologize. *I'm not your son, I am no one you know.* I was ashamed of myself. To turn away unheeding from another who begs you. But my brother was muttering in my ear, Keep moving. They won't follow us. They do this with everybody, I told you. It shook me up the first time, too. But you get used to it. They won't remember, see. They won't remember five minutes from now. Just don't make eye contact with them and you'll be fine.

I pushed my brother's fingers from my arm. Coldly I said, I don't like to be rude to old people.

We're not being rude for Christ's sake! It's what you have to do.

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THE VISITWITH Dad -- My first at the Manor.

I'd stayed away for as long as I could but now I was here.

Dad, hi! H'lo Dad.

Hi Dad! Hey. Looking good Dad ...

Dad this is Norm, I'm Vince. You know ... Your sons. Hi Dad.

Your sons, Dad. Hey this is quite a place. Quite a ...

In this way the visit with Dad began with ebullient spirits and raised smiling voices.

This isn't Dad. This elderly man. Not Dad any longer. We could not look at each other, our eyes could not meet out of dread of *Then we are not brothers, either. For we have no father any longer.*

Patients like Dad were outfitted with unremovable bracelets around their left wrists with metal tags that, if brought through electronic detectors without clearance, set off alarms through the facility.

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I was wondering how many times Dad had tried to escape, and when had been his last, or his most recent attempt. I was wondering how far the old man had gotten before the alarms went off. Before he was restrained. And how exactly was he restrained. Were *physical restraints* involved. Did *strait jackets* still exist.

I would not ask where Dad believed he was escaping to. The old house was gone. The past in which Dad had lived was gone. Nothing remained.

TIME FOR A walk?

My brother was on his feet. I saw that his jaws were stubbled and that the stubble glinted gray. My younger brother, no longer young! When I spoke, which had not been often in Dad's room, my voice cut the air like an awkwardly brandished blade, a machete perhaps. I was remembering who the sunken-chested man was, I thought. Who the sunken-chested man had been.

Three of us on our feet. My brother led the way. We walked slowly. There was no hurry. My brother led us past a nurses' aide putting soiled diapers into a black

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plastic bag on a cart. The double door to the garden was unlocked. My brother was saying in his loud cheerful voice, Dad is one of the best gardeners here. Dad, show us your tomatoes.

In my right hand, somehow related to this strange cessation of time, was an elderly man's hand. It was a bony hand, unresisting. My brother gripped the elderly man's other hand in his left hand. Dad's hand trembled yet remained unresisting, like a hand made of slightly crumbling clay.

We were not alone in the garden. Other grown children were visiting with elderly adults. Never more than three individuals in a party, for too many visitors confuse the elderly residents. Before my brother had punched in the code to open the doors, he'd told me that Dad no longer recognized himself in mirrors, so don't expect him to recognize you.

I had not that expectation. I took my cue from my brother, I smiled. I had no expectations.

I was calm recalling: the sunken-chested man with the singed face, Mr. M_ who'd taught junior high

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math. He'd taught me, he'd taught my younger brother. More than thirty years ago he'd taught us. Mr. M_ was not a name I wished to recall. Mr. M_ had taught at Yewville Junior High for a long time before they'd made him retire. Under threat of a lawsuit, or an arrest.

Certain boys were Mr. M_'s targets. You could see why certain boys were not Mr. M_'s targets for he never dared single out any strong-willed or defiant boy, or any boy from a prominent family, and boys of limited intelligence he ignored; but you could not always predict which boys, out of a number of possibilities, he would choose to torment. Vulnerable boys, shy boys. Small-boned boys. Boys with girls' faces. Rarely homely boys. Never handicapped boys. Never Italian or Negro boys.

First he'd call on you in class and if you gave the right answer he'd call on you repeatedly until at last you gave a wrong answer. Once summoning me forward to his teacher's desk at the front of the room. Making of me a witness to his red-inked pen darting and swooping over my math test like a miniature deranged hawk. I had mis-numbered the questions! I was a careless boy! Might've

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had a grade of ninety-eight but now had a grade of forty-eight. Tears welled in my eyes. My nose ran. Disgusted Mr. M_ tossed a tissue at me. It might have been a used tissue, out of his baggy pants pocket. Wipe your nose, Mr. M_ said. Stand up straight, Mr. M_ said. What a careless boy you are, not nearly so smart as you think you are, *I've got your number.* For it was so, there were boys (but never girls, and we never wondered why) of whom Mr. M_ could boast *I've got your number.*

Almost time for dinner, Dad. My brother spoke brightly as if he'd made a new discovery, and it pleased him. I had forgotten that time wasn't fixed like concrete but in fact was fluid as sand, or water. I had forgotten that even misery can end.

Got your number, got your number. Just ahead the sunken-chested old man with the singed face, the thick-lensed glasses taped to his head, was leaning on his cane. Again we must pass close by him. He wished to block our way. Here was Mr. M- wizened as a scrawny child. His face had lost its fat, his cheeks were papery thin and flushed as if with fever. I saw how, as his eyes

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lighted upon us, Mr. M-'s expression turned hopeful, shrewd. For the first time I saw how his dentures glared like cheap porcelain.

"Boys? Take me with you? Take me with you?" He lurched near me, his palsied hand groped for my arm, and I shoved him from me. Mr. M_'s fetid breath in my face, that made me gag.

"Don't touch me," I said. :You're not going anywhere with anyone, you old bastard. Your place is here, you get to die here."

My brother turned an incredulous face to me. Yanking at my arm to pull me away from the tottering old man who gaped at me as if he hadn't heard a syllable of what I'd said.

Norm! For Christ's sake.

Why didn't you warn me, I asked my brother. You knew who he was.

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AWARD HISTORY

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